

■ STRATEGIC INTELLIGENCE REPORT | APRIL 2026

Orbital Stellar

Competitive Intelligence & 20-Year Strategic Dominance Blueprint — The definitive positioning document for Stellar’s event infrastructure layer

PREPARED	CLASSIFICATION	SCOPE	HORIZON
April 14, 2026	Internal — Strategic Planning	Stellar Blockchain Ecosystem	20 Years (2026–2046)

Contains two sections — Part I: Competitive Analysis · Part II: Strategic Dominance Blueprint



PART ONE

Competitive Intelligence Report

A world-class market analysis of the Stellar blockchain developer ecosystem — strengths, weaknesses, and the competitive landscape Orbital enters.

Executive Summary

Orbital Stellar enters the market at a uniquely auspicious inflection point. The Stellar network is undergoing its most significant infrastructure maturation since launch — Soroban smart contracts are live on mainnet, Horizon is being phased out in favour of Stellar RPC, and major multi-chain infrastructure providers are only now beginning to extend Stellar support.

The event infrastructure layer — the specific domain Orbital occupies — **remains largely unaddressed for Stellar**. No competitor today offers the combination of real-time SSE streaming, HMAC-signed webhook delivery, and a native React SDK purpose-built for the Stellar protocol.

However, the window is not unlimited. QuickNode’s Q1 2026 Stellar webhook expansion and Moralis’s early-access Stellar Streams represent well-capitalised, multi-chain competitors moving in. Orbital must establish deep developer trust and protocol-level differentiation before these players achieve feature parity.

Market Landscape — Four Layers

Layer	Players	Orbital’s Relationship
Protocol Layer	SDF, Horizon, Soroban RPC	Upstream dependency
Data & Indexing	Allium, SubQuery, Goldsky, The Graph	Adjacent / indirect competition
Event & Webhook Infrastructure	QuickNode, Moralis, Sorobanhooks	Direct competition
General Webhook Infrastructure	Hookdeck, Svix, Convoy	Indirect / enterprise benchmark

Competitor Profiles

Horizon API & Stellar RPC (SDF)

OFFICIAL PROTOCOL

THREAT: MEDIUM

The Stellar Development Foundation provides Horizon (being deprecated) and Soroban RPC. Horizon exposes native SSE streaming but requires developers to manage persistent connections, handle reconnection logic, and build delivery mechanisms manually. **Soroban RPC's critical constraint: a 7-day event retention window.**

STRENGTHS

- + Official, trusted source of truth
- + Free with no default rate limits
- + Protocol-level knowledge

WEAKNESSES

- Horizon deprecated — no new features
- 7-day retention limit (Soroban)
- No webhooks, no React SDK

QuickNode

MULTI-CHAIN INFRASTRUCTURE

THREAT: HIGH

The most significant near-term threat. Q1 2026 QuickNode expanded its webhook offering to Stellar with wallet transaction monitoring, HMAC-SHA256 verification, IP allowlisting, and retry mechanisms. **Pricing starts at \$49/month.** 250,000+ developers across 30+ chains are already on the platform.

STRENGTHS

- + Massive, established developer base
- + Battle-tested webhook infrastructure
- + Multi-chain consolidation stickiness
- + Enterprise relationships & SLA credibility

WEAKNESSES

- Generic DX — not Stellar-native
- No React hooks for Stellar
- No SSE streaming interface
- Overhead cost for Stellar-only developers

Moralis

MULTI-CHAIN DATA PLATFORM

THREAT: MEDIUM

Early access Stellar APIs, Streams, and Datasets. Pitches unified APIs across Stellar, EVM, and Solana. Not production-ready — early-access programme introduces instability and documentation gaps. Operates as a data warehouse, not a low-latency event delivery service.

STRENGTHS

- + Familiar SDK patterns across chains
- + Cross-chain data unification

WEAKNESSES

- Stellar support not production-ready
- EVM-first mental model
- No SSE streaming or React hooks

Sorobanhooks

SOROBAN-SPECIFIC

THREAT: LOW-MEDIUM

The only existing service specifically targeting Soroban smart contract event webhooks on Stellar. First-mover advantage, but limited documentation, no SDK layer, no SSE streaming, and Soroban-only coverage (no classic payment events). Small team with no enterprise credibility or SLA guarantees.

The Graph

DECENTRALISED INDEXER

THREAT: LOW

Decentralised indexing via subgraphs. Now supports Stellar. A query layer — not an event delivery layer. Significant developer overhead, no real-time push delivery, no React hooks for Stellar. Serves a fundamentally different job-to-be-done (historical analytics vs. real-time delivery).

Hookdeck & Svix — Enterprise Benchmark

GENERAL WEBHOOK
INFRASTRUCTURE

BENCHMARK
ONLY

Not Stellar competitors, but the enterprise reliability benchmark sophisticated buyers hold Orbital against. Hookdeck: 99.99% uptime, 7-day/50-retry guarantees. Svix: SOC 2 Type II, HIPAA, PCI-DSS certified. These define what “production-grade” means in the webhook infrastructure category.

Pricing Landscape

Service	Model	Typical Cost
Horizon / Stellar RPC	Free (official)	\$0
QuickNode	Tiered + usage	\$49/month base
Moralis	CU-based tiers	\$99–\$999/month
OBSRVR	Usage-based	\$0.00007/API call
Hookdeck	Usage-based	Custom
Svix	SaaS tiers	\$99–\$999/month

Competitive Matrix

Capability	Orbital	QuickNode	Moralis	Sorobanhooks	The Graph	Horizon
Stellar-native design	✓	~	~	✓	~	✓
Real-time SSE streaming	✓	X	X	X	X	~
HMAC-signed webhooks	✓	✓	✓	?	X	X
React hooks SDK	✓	X	X	X	X	X
Auto reconnection + backoff	✓	N/A	N/A	?	N/A	X
Soroban contract events	Roadmap	~	~	✓	✓	X
Event persistence / replay	X	✓	✓	?	✓	X
Published uptime SLA	X	✓	✓	X	✓	✓
Open source (MIT)	✓	X	X	?	✓	✓
Production-ready today	Partial	✓	Partial	?	✓	✓

Orbital SWOT Analysis

S — STRENGTHS

- S1

Stellar-native protocol depth — only service designed exclusively for Stellar’s model
- S2

First React hooks library for Stellar real-time data (first-mover advantage)
- S3

Multi-modal delivery: SSE + webhooks + React hooks in one coherent product
- S4

Security-first: HMAC, timing-safe comparison, SSRF protection baked in
- S5

Modular MIT-licensed architecture enabling low-risk, granular adoption
- S6

Deep SDK roadmap extending toward a full Stellar developer platform

W — WEAKNESSES

- W1

In-memory webhook registry — lost on server restart, not production-safe
- W2

Payment events only — no DEX, account creation, or Soroban events yet
- W3

No Soroban smart contract support (fastest-growing Stellar segment)
- W4

No uptime SLA, no status page, no public reliability commitment
- W5

No compliance certifications (SOC 2) blocking enterprise procurement
- W6

v0.0.0 signal — API instability perception, no formal stability pledge

O — OPPORTUNITIES

- O1 Stellar developer tooling lags Ethereum by 3–5 years — ecosystem underserved
- O2 Soroban event infrastructure is greenfield — 7-day retention is a known pain
- O3 SDF Developer Grants & SCF funding align directly with Orbital's mission
- O4 React hooks lock-in mirrors Wagmi's trajectory on Ethereum — durable moat
- O5 x402 machine-to-machine payments — Stellar is the ideal AI agent settlement layer
- O6 Real-world finance adoption (CBDC, remittances, USDC) = high-value end market

T — THREATS

- T1 QuickNode achieving feature parity within 12–18 months via engineering scale
- T2 SDF building first-party event infrastructure (low probability, high impact)
- T3 Breaking changes in Horizon/Stellar RPC upstream dependency
- T4 Soroban event complexity outpacing development speed
- T5 Ecosystem fragmentation preventing any player reaching critical mass



PART TWO

The 20-Year Dominance Blueprint

A CEO-level strategic plan for building Orbital into the irreplaceable infrastructure layer of the Stellar economy — from grant positioning in week one to protocol-level permanence at year twenty.

The Founding Thesis

“Orbital’s purpose is not to build a webhook service. Orbital’s purpose is to become the connective tissue between the Stellar protocol and every application, agent, and machine that interacts with it.”

The competitive analysis reveals a market gap. This plan reveals a market destiny. **Gap-filling creates a product. Destiny-claiming creates a platform.** Platforms become infrastructure. Infrastructure becomes indispensable. Indispensable infrastructure accumulates value for decades.

The 20-year ambition: Orbital becomes so deeply embedded in the Stellar developer ecosystem that removing it would require rewriting the internet-facing layer of the Stellar economy itself. This is how Stripe became the internet’s payment layer. How Twilio became the internet’s communication layer. How AWS became the internet’s compute layer. Each started by solving a specific developer pain and expanded outward, one layer at a time, until they were foundational.

Orbital starts with events. It ends with everything that touches Stellar.

The Four Strategic Eras

ERA I · MONTHS 0–18

Foundation & Legitimacy

Fix critical production gaps, establish grant eligibility, plant the ecosystem flag. Competitive posture: collaborative. Orbital is not yet big enough to threaten anyone — use that invisibility strategically.

ERA II · YEARS 2–5

Ecosystem Ownership

Become the standard. Expand faster than competitors can catch up. Every new capability Orbital ships is a capability competitors must match before they can compete, not before they can win.

ERA III · YEARS 5–10

Infrastructure Independence & AI Integration

Own the data layer. Integrate the agentic AI economy. Become unreplaceable. Define the category rather than compete within it. Orbital sets the standard others must meet.

ERA IV · YEARS 10–20

Protocol-Level Permanence

Become infrastructure. Not infrastructure that runs on Stellar — infrastructure that is part of what Stellar means to developers. The reference against which new entrants are evaluated.

Era I — Foundation & Legitimacy (Months 0–18)

Weeks 1–6: The Fundable Product

Before seeking a single dollar of external funding, three engineering decisions must be made. Grant committees, angel investors, and developer advocates all look for the same signal: *does this team ship, and do they understand what production means?*

DECISION 1 — PERSISTENCE LAYER

Replace the in-memory webhook registry with **PostgreSQL**. Signals scale. Enables event history queries, audit logs, and analytics. Wrap it behind a repository interface from day one so the underlying store can change without breaking the API.

DECISION 2 — FULL EVENT COVERAGE

Extend `EventEngine` to normalise the full Stellar operation taxonomy: `create_account`, `change_trust`, `manage_sell_offer`, `path_payment`, `invoke_host_function` (Soroban). Each new event type doubles the addressable use case without changing the architecture.

DECISION 3 — VERSION 1.0 & STABILITY PLEDGE

Publish `1.0.0` with a documented breaking-change policy and `CHANGELOG.md`. This converts Orbital from an interesting experiment into a project developers can responsibly depend on.

Weeks 7–12: Grant Capture (Parallel Workstreams)

- **SDF Developer Grants** — Highest priority. Frame Orbital as ecosystem infrastructure. Cite the 7-day Soroban retention problem and the React hooks gap.
- **Stellar Community Fund (SCF)** — Community voting model, lower barriers. Submit immediately after SDF application.
- **Bitcoin Grants** — Quadratic funding builds community visibility while generating capital.
- **Angel Investors** — Identify angels with prior Stellar infrastructure investments. Seek \$50K–\$250K cheques. Target total by Month 12: **\$150K–\$500K combined**.

Months 6–18: Ecosystem Planting

- **Tutorial Strategy** — Three tutorials/month targeting specific Stellar developer use cases, each using Orbital exclusively, seeding GitHub repos with Orbital as a dependency.
- **Boilerplate Strategy** — Publish `orbital-next-starter`, `orbital-express-starter`, `orbital-anchor-starter`. Developers who start from a boilerplate almost never remove core dependencies.
- **Documentation Strategy** — Submit to `developers.stellar.org` community tools listing. Contribute examples to the SDF JavaScript SDK repository.

- **Ambassador Strategy** — Identify top five Stellar community contributors. Offer early access and co-authorship credit. Their Discord endorsement outweighs any advertising spend.

ERA I SUCCESS CRITERIA

≥500 npm downloads/week · ≥\$150K external funding · ≥10 public production applications · Full Stellar operation taxonomy · PostgreSQL registry · Status page live · v1.0.0 published

Era II — Ecosystem Ownership (Years 2–5)

The SDK Platform Strategy — The Wagmi Moment for Stellar

@orbital/hooks — Data Hooks

`useAccount()`, `useBalance()`, `useTransaction()`, `useOrderBook()`. Real-time by default, TypeScript-first, composable, testable. A developer who reaches for `useBalance()` instead of writing a raw Horizon query never thinks about Horizon again.

@orbital/auth — Identity & Wallet

Embedded wallets via WebAuthn/passkeys, fee sponsorship, WalletConnect. The first developer-grade passkey wallet SDK on Stellar. A developer who uses Orbital for auth has committed at the identity layer — structurally very difficult to undo.

@orbital/payments — Transaction Primitives

Send, receive, swap (path payment), payroll batch disbursement. An application built entirely with Orbital SDKs never touches the raw Stellar SDK. The protocol becomes an implementation detail Orbital manages.

@orbital/analytics — Event Intelligence

Dashboard for event volume, delivery rates, latency metrics, anomaly detection. First product that begins generating a proprietary data asset — the foundation of Orbital's long-term data moat.

The Soroban Event Standard

Build and maintain a public **Soroban Contract ABI Registry** — analogous to Etherscan's verified contract database — and use it to auto-decode Soroban events into typed, human-readable JSON. Instead of raw XDR blobs, a developer receives structured event payloads like:

```
{ "type": "swap.executed", "tokenIn": "USDC:GA5...", "tokenOut": "XLM",
  "amountIn": "100.00", "amountOut": "1243.50", "trader": "GABC...",
  "timestamp": "2026-04-14T12:00:00Z" }
```

The registry is open-source, community-contributed, and takes years to build — making it extremely difficult for a competitor to replicate from scratch. This is a durable data moat.

Horizon Dependency Reduction — Three Steps

- **Step 1:** Support Stellar RPC alongside Horizon. Developers using Orbital do nothing during the protocol migration — Orbital handles it transparently.
- **Step 2:** By Year 3, operate Orbital's own Stellar full nodes (2+ regions). Decouples uptime from SDF public endpoints, reduces latency, creates data sovereignty.
- **Step 3:** By Year 4, Orbital's archival nodes accumulate the most comprehensive, queryable Stellar event database in existence — including history older than Soroban RPC's 7-day window.

Managed SaaS Tiers

Tier	Price	Events/Month	SLA	Target
Free (Self-Hosted)	\$0	Unlimited	DIY	Developer acquisition
Developer	\$29/mo	100K	99.9%	Indie / small projects
Startup	\$149/mo	500K	99.95%	Scaling applications
Business	\$499/mo	5M	99.99%	Fintech operators
Enterprise	Custom	Unlimited	Negotiated	Regulated institutions

ERA II SUCCESS CRITERIA (YEAR 5)

≥5,000 npm downloads/week · ≥\$2M ARR · ≥100 public production applications · Soroban ABI registry live ·
Orbital-operated nodes (2+ regions) · SOC 2 Type II · Series A (\$3M–\$8M)

Era III — Infrastructure Independence & AI Integration (Years 5–10)

CRITICAL EMERGING OPPORTUNITY

The blockchain industry is converging with the AI agent economy around **machine-to-machine payments with cryptographic finality**. Stellar satisfies this better than any other L1: 3–5 second finality, sub-cent fees, built-in DEX, path payments, and Soroban for programmable logic. This convergence is Orbital's largest long-term market.

The x402 Protocol — The Agentic Payment Layer

x402 uses the HTTP `402 Payment Required` status code as a machine-readable payment trigger. When an AI agent requests a resource and receives a 402 response, it automatically processes a micropayment and retries. x402 is currently being built primarily for EVM chains (Base/Coinbase), but x402 is protocol-agnostic — it specifies an HTTP header format, not a blockchain. **There is currently no Stellar implementation of x402. This is Orbital's to build.**

@orbital/x402

Express/Next.js middleware adding x402 payment verification to any API endpoint. An API developer adds three lines and begins earning micropayments from AI agents automatically on Stellar rails.

@orbital/agent-sdk

Payment client for AI agents: x402 negotiation, Stellar transaction construction, confirmation waiting. The SDK any AI agent developer reaches for when their agent needs to pay for things.

@orbital/payment-gateway

Hosted x402 verification service. AI agents pay → Orbital confirms → API resources are released. Orbital becomes the payment gateway of the agentic internet, built on Stellar rails.

The AI-to-AI Flywheel

More AI agents → more Stellar transactions → more events → richer data layer → more valuable analytics → more operators → more agents. A compounding loop that strengthens with every new agent.

Data Sovereignty & Protocol Influence

By Year 6, Orbital's archival nodes have accumulated years of complete Stellar event history — a proprietary asset that cannot be purchased, licensed, or replicated by a late-starting competitor. `@orbital/data-api` monetises this through usage-based pricing, analytics dashboards, data exports, institutional licensing, and AI training dataset sales.

SEP Authorship: Author or co-author Stellar Ecosystem Proposals on event standardisation, webhook specifications, and contract event schemas. If the Stellar protocol's event format *is* the format Orbital uses, competitors must conform to Orbital's standard.

Geographic Expansion & Anchor Integration

By Year 6–7, deploy infrastructure in Lagos, Nairobi, Mumbai, and São Paulo — Stellar's primary real-world financial corridors. `@orbital/anchor-sdk` delivers SEP-6/24/31 transaction lifecycle events, compliance event routing, and

FATF-compliant audit logs to Stellar Anchors (fiat on/off-ramp operators). A single anchor enterprise customer (\$2K–\$10K/month) equals 100+ individual developer subscriptions.

ERA III SUCCESS CRITERIA (YEAR 10)

≥\$15M ARR · x402 live with ≥1,000 AI agent integrations · Nodes in ≥5 regions · 2+ SEPs authored · Complete archival database · ≥10 enterprise anchor customers · Series B/C (\$20M–\$50M) · 30–50 person team

Era IV — Protocol-Level Permanence (Years 10–20)

The Orbital Network

By Year 10–12, launch **The Orbital Network** — a decentralised operator model where validated third parties run Orbital relay nodes, contribute to the event routing network, and earn fees for reliable delivery. This is not a token launch. It is an infrastructure cooperative model analogous to Cloudflare’s network of data centres under a single quality standard. Orbital sets the protocol, certifies operators, maintains the client-facing API. The decentralisation removes the “single point of failure” objection from enterprise procurement.

The Orbital Identity Layer

By Year 12, `@orbital/auth` has matured into the **Stellar Identity Standard** — the way applications verify who their users are on the Stellar network. Federated Stellar addresses, passkey-based embedded wallets, and federated identity verification create a credential layer Orbital manages across the entire Stellar application ecosystem. If Orbital manages identity across Stellar applications, it offers cross-application portability — a user’s Orbital identity works in every Orbital-integrated application. This is the Stellar equivalent of Sign in with Google, with user-controlled, self-sovereign identity.

CBDC Infrastructure

Central banks exploring CBDC on Stellar need event infrastructure, compliance monitoring, transaction surveillance APIs, and developer tooling. By Year 12–15, Orbital is the natural infrastructure partner — not because of lobbying, but because it is the only company that has been running production-grade Stellar event infrastructure for a decade with documented reliability, compliance certifications, and a global node network. **A single CBDC partnership represents a step-change in Orbital’s revenue profile.**

AI Agent Compliance Infrastructure — Year 15 Vision

By Year 15, millions of autonomous agents transact on blockchain rails. Those using Stellar use Orbital’s x402 infrastructure. Orbital becomes the **compliance infrastructure for AI agent activity** — regulators mandating oversight of autonomous payment systems need a trusted, auditable infrastructure layer. The companies that own this data when regulation arrives will have a decade-long advantage over any competitor trying to enter.

ERA IV SUCCESS CRITERIA (YEAR 20)

\$75M–\$200M ARR · Orbital Network (decentralised operators) · Stellar identity standard · CBDC infrastructure partnerships · AI agent compliance infrastructure · Protocol-level SEP influence · Exit optionality: SDF acquisition, payments conglomerate, or IPO

Six Operating Principles for 20-Year Durability

01 Open Source the Core, Monetise the Operations

The SDKs and libraries remain open source forever. The value Orbital captures is in operating the infrastructure — nodes, databases, delivery network, compliance certifications. Open source is not charity; it is the most effective customer acquisition strategy for developer tools.

02 Never Outpace Stellar’s Ecosystem

Every new product must be anchored to a current or clearly emerging Stellar developer need. This discipline prevents scope creep and keeps Orbital’s value proposition coherent across two decades.

03 Reliability Is the Product

The event infrastructure business is not won by features — it is won by reliability. A developer who experiences one lost webhook event loses trust. That trust, once lost, is almost impossible to recover. Every decision must pass the reliability test first.

04 Developer Trust Is a Balance Sheet Asset

A developer who trusts Orbital for events will try Orbital for hooks. A developer who trusts Orbital for hooks will try Orbital for auth. Each positive experience increases the probability of expansion. Treat every developer interaction as a long-term balance sheet entry.

05 Protocol Influence Is a Competitive Moat

Contributing to SEPs, running validators, advising SDF — these are competitive activities, not goodwill. The company that shapes the protocol’s evolution has a durable advantage over any company that merely adapts to it.

06 Build for the Next Era While Executing in the Current One

The most expensive mistakes in long-horizon technology companies are architectural. Every architecture decision must be made correctly at the time, not retrofitted later. The PostgreSQL choice in Era I, the node operation in Era II, the decentralised network in Era III — each is a bet made at the right time or not at all.

20-Year Condensed Roadmap

Period	Phase	Primary Deliverable	Revenue Target
Months 1–6	Foundation	Persistent registry, full event coverage, v1.0.0	—
Months 6–12	Grant Capture	SDF grant, SCF, angel funding, community adoption	\$0 (grant-funded)
Years 1–2	Ecosystem Planting	SDKs, boilerplates, tutorials, npm presence	\$50K–\$150K ARR

Period	Phase	Primary Deliverable	Revenue Target
Years 2–3	Managed SaaS	Hosted product, tiered pricing, SOC 2 certification	\$300K–\$750K ARR
Years 3–5	Node Independence	Own Stellar nodes, archival database, ABI registry	\$1M–\$3M ARR
Years 5–7	x402 & AI Agents	x402 middleware, agent-sdk, AI payment infrastructure	\$5M–\$10M ARR
Years 7–10	Data Sovereignty	Data API, anchor SDK, geographic expansion, SEPs	\$10M–\$20M ARR
Years 10–15	Network Decentralisation	Orbital Network, identity layer, CBDC infrastructure	\$30M–\$75M ARR
Years 15–20	Protocol Permanence	AI agent compliance, multi-CBDC partnerships	\$75M–\$200M ARR

Final Word

Twenty years is not a plan — it is a direction. The specific products will change. The specific competitors will change. The AI agent economy, x402, and CBDC infrastructure are educated bets on where the world is moving, not certainties.

The direction, however, is not a bet — it is a logical extension of a single insight: **the Stellar network will grow. Everything that grows on it will need to send and receive events. The company that owns that infrastructure layer owns the economic surface of Stellar’s future.**

Orbital does not need to be the biggest blockchain company. It does not need to compete across every chain. It needs to be indispensable to every serious developer building on Stellar. Indispensability at the infrastructure layer, in a network growing toward mainstream financial adoption, is one of the most durable business positions available in technology.

Build the foundation correctly. Ship reliably. Earn trust one developer at a time. **The twenty years take care of themselves.**

20-YEAR ARR TARGET

\$200M

Upper bound of Era IV projection

COMPETITIVE WINDOW

12–18mo

Before QuickNode/Moralis achieve parity

YEAR 5 FUNDING TARGET

\$8M

Series A to fund Era III build-out

This document is prepared for internal strategic planning purposes and contains forward-looking projections based on publicly available market data, ecosystem research, and comparable infrastructure business trajectories as of April 2026. All revenue projections are directional estimates and should not be construed as financial forecasts. Orbital Stellar remains limited to the Stellar blockchain ecosystem in scope across all projected eras.